IELTS ACADEMIC · RESTRICTED STAFF MATERIAL

IELTS Academic Set 21

PRIVATE STAFF answer key and Listening transcript

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Listening

IELTS-style Listening Set 21 - Answer Key

Capitalisation is not assessed. Answers shown in parentheses are accepted alternatives only where explicitly listed.

Question	Answer	Task type
1	Carmichael	Form completion
2	18 (18th/eighteenth)	Form completion
3	35 (thirty-five)	Form completion
4	9.30 (9:30/09.30/09:30/nine thirty)	Form completion
5	mirrors	Form completion
6	4,800 (4800)	Form completion
7	48 (forty-eight)	Table completion
8	corner guards	Table completion
9	combination	Table completion
10	5 (five)	Table completion
11	C	Matching
12	A	Matching
13	G	Matching
14	E	Matching
15	B	Matching
16	Larkhill Road	Short answer
17	photo ID	Short answer

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Question	Answer	Task type
18	upstairs landing	Short answer
19	every week	Short answer
20	01632 960 412 (01632960412)	Short answer
21	A	Multiple choice
22	C	Multiple choice
23	A	Multiple choice
24	B	Multiple choice
25	C	Multiple choice
26	B	Matching
27	D	Matching
28	C	Matching
29	E	Matching
30	F	Matching
31	microorganisms	Note completion
32	buckets	Note completion
33	openings	Note completion
34	microscope	Note completion
35	collection	Note completion
36	contamination	Note completion
37	threshing	Flow-chart completion
38	fine sieving	Flow-chart completion
39	roasted	Flow-chart completion
40	storage pests	Flow-chart completion

Count and constraint audit

- 40 questions total: 10 per part.
- Task-type totals: 20 completion, 10 matching, 5 short answer, 5 multiple choice.
- Every keyed answer occurs after the preceding answer in the recording.
- Questions 1-6: maximum one word and/or one number.
- Questions 7-10, 16-20: maximum two words and/or one number.
- Questions 31-36: one word only.
- Questions 37-40: maximum two words.

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Listening transcript

IELTS-style Listening Set 21 - Production Script

Status: release candidate. Editorial and technical gates passed; human listening approval pending. This is original, unofficial practice material.

Production notation

- VOICE identifies the casting slot; the accent must come from a verified native reference rather than phonetic imitation.
- PAUSE is an edit instruction and is not spoken.
- PRE-READ and REVIEW indicate silent candidate time and must not be read as a duration.
- Natural micro-pauses inside an utterance are left to performance direction.
- No music or environmental effects are required.

Opening

[SEGMENT O-01 | VOICE: NARRATOR, British female | PAUSE BEFORE: 1.0 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

You are about to hear an IELTS-style Listening practice test. There are four parts and forty questions. You will hear each recording once only. Answer the questions as you listen. At the end of each part, you will have a short time to check your answers.

Part 1 - Questions 1-10

[SEGMENT P1-N01 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 30 s]

Part 1. You will hear a man arranging temporary storage for household belongings. First, look at Questions 1 to 6.

[SEGMENT P1-N01B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen carefully and answer Questions 1 to 6.

[SEGMENT P1-01 | VOICE: AMELIA REED, Irish female storage adviser | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Good morning. You've reached Merton Self Store. My name's Amelia. How can I help?

[SEGMENT P1-02 | VOICE: NOAH CARMICHAEL, British male customer | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Hello. I'm moving out next month, but my new flat won't be ready for about six weeks. I need somewhere secure during that gap.

[SEGMENT P1-03 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

That should be straightforward. I'll take a few details and work out what size of unit you need. Could I start with your full name?

[SEGMENT P1-04 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

It's Noah Carmichael.

[SEGMENT P1-05 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Thank you. And when would you like the storage period to begin?

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[SEGMENT P1-06 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

I first wrote the sixteenth of October because my brother offered his van that day. He has since learned he won't be free until two days later, so the storage should actually start on the eighteenth.

[SEGMENT P1-07 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

The eighteenth of October. Fine. Now, roughly how much are you storing? A one-bedroom flat can mean very different things.

[SEGMENT P1-08 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

There's no sofa or dining table. The large pieces are a double mattress, a narrow bookcase, six dining chairs and a bicycle. Then I've got about twenty boxes. I looked online and wondered whether a forty-square-foot unit would be safest.

[SEGMENT P1-09 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Forty would leave quite a lot of unused space. Twenty-five would be too tight once the mattress is inside, but the thirty-five-square-foot unit should take everything and still leave a passage down the middle. I'll recommend thirty-five.

[SEGMENT P1-10 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

That sounds better. I'd rather not pay for empty floor space.

[SEGMENT P1-11 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Exactly. Our ordinary access hours finish at seven in the evening. Would that suit you?

[SEGMENT P1-12 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Not every day. I can usually arrive by eight, but on the first evening I'll be travelling with the van and may not get there until nine. Could I have access until half past nine?

[SEGMENT P1-13 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Yes. We can put late access on your account, which will let your entry code work until nine thirty p.m. After that, the security system closes the building automatically.

[SEGMENT P1-14 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Nine thirty is plenty.

[SEGMENT P1-15 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Are there any unusually fragile belongings? I don't need a list of ordinary kitchen glass, but we record larger breakable items for insurance.

[SEGMENT P1-16 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

I've got three framed prints, though those have plastic rather than glass. The things I'm concerned about are two framed mirrors. They belonged to my grandparents, so I'll wrap them separately.

[SEGMENT P1-17 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

I'll note two framed mirrors. And finally, what would it cost to replace everything you plan to store?

[SEGMENT P1-18 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

I made a list yesterday. The furniture, boxes and mirrors came to four thousand pounds. I'd forgotten the bicycle, though, and replacing that would cost about eight hundred. So the total should be four thousand eight hundred.

[SEGMENT P1-19 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.7 s]

Good. I've entered a declared value of four thousand eight hundred pounds.

[SEGMENT P1-N02 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 20 s]

Now look at Questions 7 to 10.

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[SEGMENT P1-N02B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen and answer Questions 7 to 10.

[SEGMENT P1-20 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Let’s go through the optional services. Do you already have transport for the first day?

[SEGMENT P1-21 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Possibly. My brother offered his van, but it’s smaller than I expected and we’d probably need three journeys.

[SEGMENT P1-22 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Our collection van is large enough for your inventory and comes with a driver and loading trolley. A weekend collection would be fifty-six pounds. As you’re coming on a Thursday, the price is forty-eight.

[SEGMENT P1-23 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Forty-eight is reasonable. Please add that.

[SEGMENT P1-24 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Would you also like the protective packing set? It contains four reusable blankets and eight corner guards. The straps belong to the van, so the driver takes those away afterwards, but you keep the guards for the whole rental.

[SEGMENT P1-25 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Yes, the corner guards will be useful for the mirrors.

[SEGMENT P1-26 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

The set costs twelve pounds. You’ll also need a lock. We used to supply one with a key, but customers often misplaced the key, so our standard lock is now a combination model. You choose the four-digit code when you arrive.

[SEGMENT P1-27 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

A combination lock is better for me. I won’t have another key to carry.

[SEGMENT P1-28 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

There is a refundable deposit as well. Once the unit has been emptied and checked, we normally return it within five working days. Some banks take another day or two to display the payment, but the refund leaves us within five.

[SEGMENT P1-29 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.45 s]

Fine. Can I pay everything by card now?

[SEGMENT P1-30 | VOICE: AMELIA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

Yes. I’ll send a secure payment link with the booking summary. Check the dates and declared value before paying, and call us if anything changes.

[SEGMENT P1-31 | VOICE: NOAH | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

I will. Thanks for making that simple.

[SEGMENT P1-N03 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: REVIEW 22.5 s]

That is the end of Part 1. Check your answers before Part 2 begins.

Part 2 - Questions 11-20

[SEGMENT P2-N01 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 30 s]

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Part 2. You will hear a fire-safety officer giving advice to residents and explaining a free home-inspection service. First, look at Questions 11 to 15.

[SEGMENT P2-N01B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen carefully and answer Questions 11 to 15.

[SEGMENT P2-01 | VOICE: KAREN MERCER, Australian female fire-safety officer | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Good evening. I'm Karen Mercer from Northgate Fire and Rescue. I'll begin with five situations that residents often ask about. There is no single device that solves every problem, so listen carefully to which action fits each situation.

[SEGMENT P2-02 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

The first concerns cooking. If steam or cooking fumes regularly set off the smoke alarm beside your kitchen, don't remove its battery. Fit a heat alarm there, while keeping an ordinary smoke alarm in the nearby hall. A fire blanket can help with a small pan fire, but it will not solve repeated false alarms.

[SEGMENT P2-03 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Second, some residents have alarms but remain uncertain about the rest of the property. They may not know whether an elderly relative could hear an alarm from a back bedroom. Rather than buying equipment at random, request a free inspection. An officer will assess the whole home, test existing devices and recommend what is actually needed.

[SEGMENT P2-04 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

The third situation is electrical. A television, portable heater and kettle should never share a lightweight extension lead. Switching one appliance off most of the time is not enough. Replace the extension lead with one rated for the required load, or have additional wall sockets installed by a qualified electrician. Moving the heater does not remove the overloaded connection.

[SEGMENT P2-05 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Fourth, many serious fires spread after people have gone to bed. Closing internal doors before sleeping slows smoke and heat and gives the alarm more time to wake everyone. Do not lock those doors, because that could delay an escape; simply shut them.

[SEGMENT P2-06 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.5 s]

The final situation involves a portable heater beside an armchair. Move the heater at least a metre from upholstered furniture, curtains and drying clothes. A fire blanket belongs in the kitchen and is not a substitute for safe distance. Also place the heater where it cannot be knocked over.

[SEGMENT P2-07 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

These recommendations deal with the immediate risk in each example. If two or more apply to your home, follow each relevant action rather than choosing only one.

[SEGMENT P2-N02 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 20 s]

Now look at Questions 16 to 20.

[SEGMENT P2-N02B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen and answer Questions 16 to 20.

[SEGMENT P2-08 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

I'll now explain our free home-inspection visits. This month, the team is concentrating on the north side of Mereford. Monday's appointments are in Quarry Lane. On Tuesday, officers will visit Larkhill Road, and Wednesday has been set aside for Northgate Crescent. If your street is not listed, you can still request a later appointment through the council website.

[SEGMENT P2-09 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

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Please remember that genuine inspectors never arrive without an appointment. Every officer will carry photo ID showing the Northgate service badge and an identification number. A uniform by itself is not proof. Ask to see the photo ID before opening the door, and telephone the service if the face or number does not match the appointment message.

[SEGMENT P2-10 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

During the visit, we will check alarm coverage. A single-storey home usually needs a smoke alarm in the hall between the living area and bedrooms. In a two-storey house, there should be one downstairs as well, but the second alarm must be on the upstairs landing, where it can be heard from every bedroom. An alarm inside only the main bedroom does not provide adequate coverage.

[SEGMENT P2-11 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Testing is just as important as location. Some packaging suggests a monthly check, and our reminder messages were once sent on the first day of each month. Current guidance is to press the test button every week. Choose a regular day so it becomes a habit. If an alarm chirps because the battery is low, replace the battery immediately rather than waiting for the weekly test.

[SEGMENT P2-12 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Appointments last about forty minutes. If you need to change yours, do not call the emergency station. Use the inspection line on zero one six three two, nine six zero, four one two. I'll repeat that: zero one six three two, nine six zero, four one two. The line is staffed from nine until five. Outside those hours, leave your name and appointment date, but never leave medical or banking information.

[SEGMENT P2-13 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

The inspection is free. Officers may supply standard alarms where none are fitted, but they do not sell products, collect donations or ask to see financial documents. If electrical work is needed, you will receive a written recommendation.

[SEGMENT P2-14 | VOICE: CALLUM | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Thank you. Booking cards are available by the exit.

[SEGMENT P2-N03 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: REVIEW 22.5 s]

That is the end of Part 2. Check your answers before Part 3 begins.

Part 3 - Questions 21-30

[SEGMENT P3-N01 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 30 s]

Part 3. You will hear two students discussing plans for an oral-history archive with their tutor. First, look at Questions 21 to 25.

[SEGMENT P3-N01B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen carefully and answer Questions 21 to 25.

[SEGMENT P3-01 | VOICE: AISHA RAHMAN, North American female tutor | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Naomi, Isaac, I've read your proposal for an archive about people who work through the night. The central idea is strong, but the sample needs reconsidering before you recruit anyone.

[SEGMENT P3-02 | VOICE: NAOMI BELL, British female student | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Is twelve interviewees too ambitious? We could reduce it to eight. I also wondered whether the age range was narrow, although our youngest participant is twenty-six and the oldest is sixty-one.

[SEGMENT P3-03 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

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Neither is the main issue. All twelve people on your list work in health care: nurses, laboratory technicians and ambulance dispatchers. That would tell us a great deal about one sector, but not about night work more generally. You need people from different occupations, even if the final sample is slightly smaller.

[SEGMENT P3-04 | VOICE: ISAAC WEBB, British male student | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

We could approach a baker, a freight controller and someone from a hotel, then keep some of the hospital staff. That would give us contrasting reasons for being awake at those hours.

[SEGMENT P3-05 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Exactly. Before the main interviews, though, I want you to run a pilot. The council offered two employees who currently work nights, but their manager would have to attend, which could limit what they say. The archive’s experienced interviewers would give useful technical advice, yet they are too familiar with oral-history conventions to behave like ordinary participants.

[SEGMENT P3-06 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

What about the archive volunteers who used to do night shifts? Three of them said they’d be happy to help.

[SEGMENT P3-07 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Use those volunteers for the pilot. They understand why the material will be preserved, but they have not conducted interviews themselves. Their feedback should expose unclear questions without using any of your main participants.

[SEGMENT P3-08 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

We also need to settle the recording format. Video would capture facial expression, and initially we thought of making both video and audio versions.

[SEGMENT P3-09 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

But two potential participants said a camera would make them self-conscious. Video files would also require far more storage. If we record audio only, we can still make careful notes about gestures that clarify what a speaker means.

[SEGMENT P3-10 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

I agree. Choose audio only. Consistent, well-recorded sound is more valuable here than poor video, and people may speak more freely without a lens pointed at them.

[SEGMENT P3-11 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

For the interview itself, I drafted a chronological sequence: childhood, first job, first night shift and then the present.

[SEGMENT P3-12 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

That order is tidy, but it may force people to spend half the session on background. A fixed list of identical questions would make comparison easy, although it could sound like a survey rather than an oral history.

[SEGMENT P3-13 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Prepare topic cards instead: sleep, food, family contact, quiet periods, emergencies and the journey home. After a short opening, let each participant choose which card to discuss next. You’ll cover the same broad areas, but the order will reflect what matters to that person.

[SEGMENT P3-14 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

That should also make the interview feel less controlled. We can keep the chronological questions only as prompts if somebody struggles to begin.

[SEGMENT P3-15 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

How should we judge whether the archive succeeds? Our proposal says twenty completed interviews, and we estimated that each would last at least forty-five minutes.

[SEGMENT P3-16 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

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Numbers and length are production targets, not the main measure of value. A long set of similar accounts would add little. Your primary measure should be the range of occupations represented. Within that range, you can report differences in age and experience.

[SEGMENT P3-17 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Right. We'll revise the recruitment table so occupational range is visible before we invite anyone else.

[SEGMENT P3-N02 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 20 s]

Now look at Questions 26 to 30.

[SEGMENT P3-N02B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen and answer Questions 26 to 30.

[SEGMENT P3-18 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Let's consider the practical problems you identified. First, privacy. Several participants are willing to describe mistakes or difficult incidents, but they do not want neighbours or employers to find their names online.

[SEGMENT P3-19 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

We planned a pre-interview phone call to explain how the website works. Would that be enough if they signed a consent form afterwards?

[SEGMENT P3-20 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

The call is good practice, but it does not protect identity. Offer pseudonyms for the public catalogue and recording. Keep the real-name list in an encrypted file available only to the archive manager. Participants can still choose to be named.

[SEGMENT P3-21 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

The next problem is fatigue. Someone finishing at six in the morning may not manage a ninety-minute interview, even after a break.

[SEGMENT P3-22 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

We could cut every interview to forty minutes, but then an important story might be stopped just as it becomes detailed.

[SEGMENT P3-23 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Divide it into two shorter sessions. Agree the second date before ending the first, and begin the follow-up with a brief summary. That gives people time to rest and often allows them to remember useful details between sessions.

[SEGMENT P3-24 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

That leads to another issue. Memories may surface during the night, when neither of us is available to record an interview. One participant said his clearest recollections come during the quiet hour before dawn.

[SEGMENT P3-25 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Could we ask people to use a phone app? It might record notifications and other sounds as well, and not everyone owns the same kind of phone.

[SEGMENT P3-26 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Lend each participant a simple recorder with a single large button. They can capture a short voice note when a memory occurs, then discuss it fully at the next session. You should copy the file and erase the device before it goes to somebody else.

[SEGMENT P3-27 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Researchers will eventually need to find relevant passages. A hundred hours of sound would be impossible to search by starting at the beginning of every recording.

[SEGMENT P3-28 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

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Removing pauses and background sound might shorten it, but we'd lose the atmosphere of the interviews.

[SEGMENT P3-29 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Retain the original recordings and create a keyword index. For each file, record the time at which subjects such as transport, meals or isolation begin. A researcher can then jump to the relevant passage without altering the source audio.

[SEGMENT P3-30 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

Finally, the automated transcripts misheard several names and changed technical terms. Hiring a professional would reduce those errors, but it would use most of our budget.

[SEGMENT P3-31 | VOICE: ISAAC | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

We could correct the obvious mistakes ourselves and mark any word we cannot understand.

[SEGMENT P3-32 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.4 s]

Do that as a first pass, then ask each participant to approve the transcript. They can correct specialised vocabulary and point out where the written wording changes their intended meaning. Keep a record of every amendment rather than silently replacing the original.

[SEGMENT P3-33 | VOICE: NAOMI | PAUSE AFTER: 0.35 s]

So we use pseudonyms, split long interviews, lend recorders, build a keyword index and return transcripts for approval. That gives us a clear revision list.

[SEGMENT P3-34 | VOICE: AISHA | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Good. Send me the revised protocol after the pilot, and we'll check it before recruitment begins.

[SEGMENT P3-N03 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: REVIEW 22.5 s]

That is the end of Part 3. Check your answers before Part 4 begins.

Part 4 - Questions 31-40

[SEGMENT P4-N01 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 30 s]

Part 4. You will hear a lecture about the recovery and interpretation of ancient seeds from waterlogged archaeological sites. First, look at Questions 31 to 36.

[SEGMENT P4-N01B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen carefully and answer Questions 31 to 36.

[SEGMENT P4-01 | VOICE: DR ZOE MADDEN, Irish female lecturer | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Today we'll examine a source of archaeological evidence that is physically small but remarkably informative: waterlogged seeds. Plant remains normally disappear quickly. In dry soil, insects, fungi and other organisms break down soft tissue until little survives. Waterlogging changes that process because the spaces in the soil remain filled with water. Oxygen cannot circulate, and the microorganisms responsible for most decay become far less active. The seed is not turned to stone; it remains organic and fragile, but decomposition slows dramatically.

[SEGMENT P4-02 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Preservation is rarely uniform across a site. An open surface may dry repeatedly and destroy its plant material, while a nearby pit stays saturated. Wooden structures are especially useful. A lining of planks around a well, or the base of a timber drain, can form a pocket that retains water even when the surrounding soil becomes drier. Archaeologists therefore record the precise deposit around every sample rather than describing an entire excavation as simply waterlogged.

[SEGMENT P4-03 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

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Collection begins before the seeds themselves are visible. Excavators place measured blocks of dark sediment in sealed buckets. Cloth bags are appropriate for dry pottery, but they allow moisture to escape, so they are unsuitable here. Each bucket receives the context number, depth and collection date on two labels: one outside and one protected beneath the lid. Until processing, the buckets are kept cool, although freezing is avoided because it can damage delicate remains.

[SEGMENT P4-04 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

In the laboratory, water is used to loosen the sediment over a sequence of sieves. The upper sieve has the widest openings. It catches gravel, along with pieces of wood or bone that must be examined separately. The material passing through then reaches progressively finer mesh. This staged approach is slower than forcing everything through one very fine screen, but it prevents the mesh from becoming blocked and reduces damage to the smallest seeds.

[SEGMENT P4-05 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

After washing, the residue is sorted while still damp. Large cereal grains may be recognised by eye, but many wild plants produce seeds only a millimetre across. Final identification is therefore carried out under a microscope. The analyst looks at overall shape, surface texture and the scar where the seed was attached to the parent plant. Colour alone is unreliable because centuries in wet sediment can darken unrelated species in similar ways.

[SEGMENT P4-06 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Identification is comparative rather than intuitive. Archaeological specimens are placed beside modern seeds of known species held in a reference collection. Good collections include natural variation: a seed from a dry hillside may be narrower than one of the same species grown beside a stream. Published photographs are helpful, but they flatten texture and scale, so they cannot fully replace physical reference material.

[SEGMENT P4-07 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Analysts must also decide whether a seed is genuinely ancient. Modern roots can penetrate an old deposit and carry recent seeds down through cracks. Earth-moving animals may do the same. Material that entered in this way is recorded as contamination, not quietly removed from the data. A pale colour, intact soft tissue or a concentration around a living root can indicate recent origin, although several signs should be considered together.

[SEGMENT P4-08 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.75 s]

Once species and context have been established, the seeds can address larger questions: what people ate, which plants grew nearby and how crops were processed. However, a list of species is only the beginning. Interpretation depends on where different remains occur and on which stages of human activity could have produced that pattern.

[SEGMENT P4-N02 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: PRE-READ 20 s]

Now look at Questions 37 to 40.

[SEGMENT P4-N02B | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

Now listen and answer Questions 37 to 40.

[SEGMENT P4-09 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.8 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Consider a case study from a small wetland settlement. Researchers took equal-volume samples from an outer yard, a roofed processing room and the area around a central hearth. Because every sample represented the same quantity of sediment, the relative abundance of plant remains could be compared. The team separated cereal grain from chaff, weed seeds and fragments of stalk, then examined how these categories were distributed.

[SEGMENT P4-10 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

The outer yard contained very little clean grain but large numbers of broken stalks. Those fragments are produced when harvested cereal heads are beaten to separate grain from the main stems. In other words, their concentration indicates threshing. The activity was probably kept outside because it required space and generated a great deal of dust. A few grains in the yard do not contradict that conclusion; some loss is inevitable during beating.

[SEGMENT P4-11 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

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The covered room presented a different pattern. Coarse stems were scarce, while small weed seeds occurred in dense patches beside low working platforms. Large weeds can be removed earlier by hand, but seeds similar in size to cereal grain survive until a finer screen is used. The evidence therefore points to fine sieving inside the covered room. Shelter would have mattered at this stage because a sudden shower could wet cleaned grain and make it difficult to store.

[SEGMENT P4-12 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Near the hearth, most grain was intact, but its surface was darkened and slightly cracked by heat. One explanation would be an accidental building fire. However, the same limited heating appeared in several occupation layers, while roof timbers showed no burning. Researchers concluded that the grain had probably been roasted deliberately in small batches. Light roasting can loosen the husk of some cereal varieties and also changes flavour.

[SEGMENT P4-13 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Finally, the team looked for evidence of long-term storage. A large granary often supports beetles and other insects that feed specifically on stored cereal. Their bodies survive well in the same waterlogged deposits as seeds. Here, however, there were no storage pests. This absence cannot prove that no grain was ever kept on the site, but combined with the small processing batches, it suggests that supplies moved through fairly quickly rather than remaining for an entire season.

[SEGMENT P4-14 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.3 s]

Taken together, the distributions form a sequence. Initial threshing occurred in the open yard. Fine cleaning took place under cover. Selected batches were roasted beside the hearth and then used or moved elsewhere before pests became established. No single seed reveals that organisation. It emerges only because recovery methods were consistent and every category, including apparent waste, was linked to its exact context.

[SEGMENT P4-15 | VOICE: ZOE | PAUSE AFTER: 0.8 s]

This is the wider value of archaeobotany. Tiny remains can reconstruct decisions about labour, space and timing, provided that excavation, laboratory processing and interpretation are treated as parts of one evidential chain.

[SEGMENT P4-N03 | VOICE: NARRATOR | PAUSE BEFORE: 0.7 s | PAUSE AFTER: 0.0 s]

That is the end of Part 4, and the end of the Listening practice test. You now have a short time to check your answers.

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Reading

Question	Answer	Accepted variants
1	iv	
2	i	
3	vii	
4	iii	
5	ix	
6	v	
7	ii	
8	working groups	groups
9	stone	
10	batter	a batter
11	through stones	
12	solution	
13	checking	
14	TRUE	
15	FALSE	
16	NOT GIVEN	
17	TRUE	
18	NOT GIVEN	
19	FALSE	
20	FALSE	
21	B	
22	F	
23	D	
24	G	
25	C	
26	E	
27	NO	
28	YES	

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Question	Answer	Accepted variants
29	NOT GIVEN	
30	YES	
31	NOT GIVEN	
32	NO	
33	YES	
34	B	
35	D	
36	A	
37	C	
38	B	
39	A	
40	D	

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